

► SCALE, PRINTS, AND DESIGN

There are so many quilt designs and fabrics to choose from that getting started on designing your quilt can be a bewildering experience. Most quilts are a mixture of printed and plain fabrics. When

using prints, first consider whether the pattern lends itself to being a primary or secondary pattern. The plain areas will act as a foil. Using a design wall can help with your planning.

THE SCALE

The size of the image – its scale – is an important factor when working with print fabrics. A large-scale pattern is generally more difficult to work with, but it can be used successfully, especially in bigger blocks.

Try combining large prints, especially conversation prints – prints that have themed motifs – with plain fabrics. Large prints are useful for making quick-and-easy baby and children's quilts. Medium-scale prints can be fussy cut (see p.38) quite effectively, and small-scale patterns are usually simple to use as they can be cut into small units that have a consistent look.

There are also hand-dyed and batik fabrics (or fabrics printed to look as if they are hand-dyed) and tone-on-tone fabrics that have tiny motifs printed on a background of the same colour that look almost like plain colours from a distance. These give more visual texture than a solid plain colour and can really help to bring a design to life.

GEOMETRIC-PATTERNED FABRICS

Fabrics such as stripes, checks, and tartans can make fascinating secondary patterns when they are cut and re-assembled. Widely used in country-style quilts, they need careful handling in order to be most effective. Stripes, in particular, can be set in different directions to create visual movement within a block, while checks and tartan can be combined with each other or with plain fabrics to great effect. Be careful to align stripes and checks when cutting and sewing.

BORDERS AND SASHING

A plain colour can act as a foil to a busy print, giving the eye somewhere to rest and providing the keen quilter with a place to show off skills. Plain sashing (see p.78) can direct a viewer to the block pattern within, and while borders can be patterned and pieced, plain borders frame and contain a quilt in a special way. Balance – between prints and plains, lights and darks, warmth and coolness – is key to any successful design, and the more quilts you look at, and make, the better your judgement will become. One way to work is to choose a main print first and then coordinate the plains and other prints around it.

CREATING A DESIGN WALL

Using a design wall is a good way to test how fabrics will look as it allows you to step back and view different options from a distance. Hang a plain white sheet over a door to make a temporary design wall, or fashion a moveable one from foam board covered with white flannel over a layer of wadding. If you have room for a permanent design wall, mount cork or foam board on a wall in your sewing area and pin fabrics to it.

Stripes

Stripes add interest that varies depending on the way the fabric is cut. Striped fabrics can be cut with the stripe, across the stripe, or at an angle to the stripe.

Plains

Plain fabrics are often used as the basis of a quilt design, as borders, and for the quilt backing.